RURAL & LANDSCAPE PLANNING

Village / small town planning

- 8th lecture -

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Lecture outline

Key topics:

- What is the role of villages and small towns in rural development?
- What are the key challenges facing small towns and villages?
- What actions or interventions can enhance villages and small towns?

Key takeaways

Introduction

**Physical transformation of villages –
from managing decline to rapid growth**

Villages play a key role in rural life:

- Residential function – part of the settlement hierarchy
- Retail and service sector
- Employment / tourism focus
- Social infrastructure

Introduction

**Physical transformation of villages –
from managing decline to rapid growth**

Villages face significant challenges:

- Erosion of distinctiveness
- Loss of retail function
- Loss of service functions (e.g., ‘thin’ markets, or austerity)
- Lack of connectivity
- Relationship with housing in open countryside

>> Towards enhancing rural sustainability

Introduction

>> Towards enhancing rural sustainability

1 Rural infrastructures
Service provision (hardware)
Social networks (software)

2 Settlement policies
Key settlements

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning
Community-led vs. planner-led planning

1 Rural infrastructures

Rural infrastructures include:

- **service provision (hardware), *community infrastructure***
  >> local transport, health care, education, affordable housing
  - hard items supplied by the market of by tax-payers

- **soft support to community infrastructure (software), *social infrastructure***
  >> community groups and local networks
  - soft things that people do themselves

1 Rural infrastructures

Service provision (hardware), *community infrastructure*

>> key goal: 'get-at-ability' and 'accessibility' (Moseley, 1979)

- local transport (different modes)
- places of employment
- schools
- healthcare
- village centre (retail, banking, shop selling groceries)

- levels of accessibility (i.e., percentage of local residents enjoying 'reasonable' access) fall in rural areas

>> **'access gap':**
live remotely and expect to drive to most basic service, or, if driving is not an option, face a long and difficult journey

1 Rural infrastructures

Soft support to community infrastructure (software), *social infrastructure*

>> people, voluntary action and local networks (Flora and Flora, 1993)

1) *community facilities (material)*
shops, village halls
buses, car-sharing schemes ('hardware' paid for by others, managed by the residents' labour)

2) *local networks (immaterial)*
residents' associations, mother and baby groups, support for the elderly

>> **leadership: 'active citizens'**

1 Rural infrastructures

Groups of resources	Main elements of which:
Economic capital >> tangible values	Transport and communications infrastructure, workspace, local economic linkages, past private investment by firms and households, range of businesses in existence
Human capital >> local population	Education, skills, health, attitudes, confidence, entrepreneurship and capacity for risk taking of the local population
Social capital >> sectorial networks	Networks and partnerships linking the public, private and voluntary sectors, the quality of local institutions and governance, trust and the shared norms that facilitate cooperation
Cultural capital >> societal values	Political consensus, civic engagement, local history, customs and heritage, 'place identity' and people's sense of place, valorisation of culture and culture as a collective resource
Environmental capital >> appraised natural assets	Natural and man-made assets that are valorised by local residents, investors and visitors; location, embracing peripherality, perceptions of peripherality and proximity to other places

Courtney & Moseley, 2008

1 Rural infrastructures

Soft support to community infrastructure (software), *social infrastructure*

>> social structures:
a crucial driver of **endogenous growth**

>> basic and fundamental resource for rural people, not a substitute for external investment

2 Settlement policies

Settlement policies:
strongly related to the question of viability of services

Key settlement policy (KSP):

- a policy to improve, further develop **the existing centres** of employment, service provision, etc., or to develop **new key settlements** through targeted investments

- key settlements: usually close to urban nodes

>> consequence of KSP: decline of non-KS, i.e., remote, dispersed rural settlements

2 Settlement policies: examples
England

Early phase (1940s-1970s):

- Rural land to be preserved for agriculture and urban land to provide the location for housing and industry

- **The concern in rural areas:**
  economic provision of services and infrastructure

- Categorisation of villages: A, B, C or D
  A – considered to grow in population and receive an investment
  D – considered to decline and receive no investment

>> changing geography of villages:
villages closer to urban centres became more popular places to live

2 Settlement policies: examples
England

Counterurbanisation (1970s-1990s):

- KS: Peri-urban areas favoured over others (e.g., far remote)
- Traditional dominance of the 'urban containment' philosophy, i.e., limiting sprawl in rural areas

>> pressured **rural areas became dominated by urban and regional planning objectives**, rather than more localised rural needs

- **Peri-urban areas** justified on a similar basis as **green belts** (Abercrombie: green belts)

2 Settlement policies: examples
England

Narrative on sustainable development (since 1990s):

- Sustainable development became the dominant justification for KSPs in national and local policy
- ‘To promote sustainable development in rural areas, housing should be located where it will enhance or maintain the vitality of rural communities’

>> very vague definition, no clear goals how to achieve it, except fostering the rural areas near urban centres

2 Settlement policies: examples
Ireland

- ‘A **dispersed settlement pattern** comprising single dwellings in the open countryside is a longstanding feature of rural areas’

(Murray, 2010)

>> Ireland resisted the influence of ’urban containment’

2 Settlement policies: examples
Romania

- Investment was channelled into '**key villages with the highest potential for growth**'

(Turnock, 1991)

>> Example: Ianca, small town newly built in 1989

>> some villages were destroyed in the late 1980s

2 Settlement policies: examples
China

- Enormous urbanisation caused some villages to be abandoned, other faced rural depopulation and sparsity of active population

>> **state-led rural settlements consolidation**
'rural collectives are encouraged or pushed (and sometimes even coerced) to relocate to newly built villages of a higher density at another location'

(Guo and Zhong, 2016)

>> opposition and resistance from local communities

2 Settlement policies: examples
The Netherlands

- Priorities:
  - preservation of the countryside for agriculture
  - housing supply tightly controlled (both in the open country as well as villages)

>> **creating rural residential environment in urban or suburban areas**

(van Dam et al., 2002)

2 Resistance to KSP

Sustainable development:

- sufficiently broad to agree with (Owen, 1996)
- sufficiently vague to allow particular perspectives to be privileged over others (Allmendinger and Haughton, 2010)

When applied to rural areas:

- sustainable development focused only on the **environment** (and not economic and social aspects), with
- a narrow focus on one aspect of the environment – **the need to reduce CO2 emissions** by
  - reducing private car use
  - allowing housing only in places with public transport provision

2 Alternatives to KSP

Shift in discourse: from 'sustainability' to 'resilience'

- Resilience: adaptability, transformability, constant change

Proposal:

- housing policy to be better integrated with community development policy
- a more sophisticated approach to determining whether particular forms of development, settlements, or individual family homes are resilient or can be made more so

2 Alternatives to KSP

More sensitive approach to village planning

>> formal instruments (e.g., neighbourhood plans)

>> informal tools (e.g., activists' incentives)

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Why do we need to combine formal and informal instruments?

Evidenced limit of statutory planning framework in regard to village planning

>> participatory involvement of **local people**

>> plan content needs to extend beyond the location, scale and design of physical development and **embrace the social, economic and cultural dimensions of village vitality**

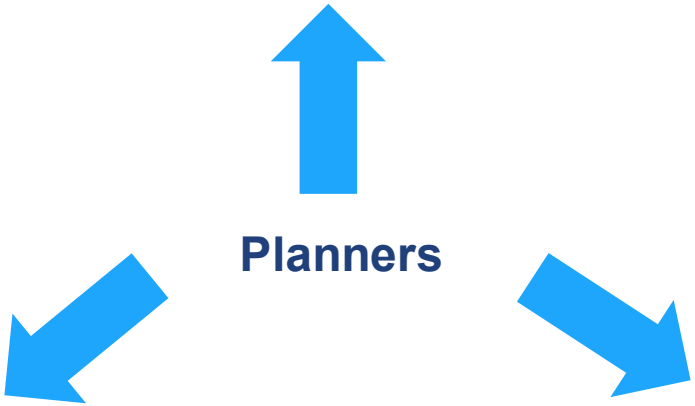
>> carefully designed **procedures** beyond regulatory land-use allocation citizen-engaged, wide-ranging and action-oriented strategic village planning

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Planners:
The day-to-day operation of the planning system is rooted in local government with decision-making in the main being the responsibility of elected representatives having regard to the **technical input and advice of professional planners.**

(Murray, 2019)

Central government / agencies
legislation
planning policy
strategic investments



Planners

developers, landowners, pressure groups, community groups and the general public

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Village residents:
a **series of social groups** with specific problems and housing needs to which rural planning should be more closely aligned

(Pahl, 1975)

- large property owners
- salaried immigrants with some capital
- those with limited income and little capital
- the retired
- council house tenants, tied cottages and other tenants
- local tradesmen and owners of small businesses

Understanding why people find themselves in a village and how they relate to where they live is key to understanding **community involvement.**

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Planners-led village plans

Operated at two scales: regional/sub-regional and local

- regional/sub-regional
  >> village as one layer in the settlement pattern
  >> KSP as a strategic framework for village planning

Example: Durham County Council (1951)

>> 121 villages out of a total of 357 towns and villages in the county were at some time placed in Category D

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Planners-led village plans

Example: Durham County Council (1951)

>> 121 villages out of a total of 357 towns and villages in the county were at some time placed in Category D

"Those from which a considerable loss of population may be expected. In these cases it is felt that there should be no further investment of capital on any considerable scale, and that any proposal to invest capital should be carefully examined. This generally means that when the existing houses become uninhabitable they should be replaced elsewhere, and that any expenditure on facilities and services in these communities which would involve public money should be limited to conform to what appears to be the possible future life of existing property in the community."

(County Council of Durham, 1951: 77–78)

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Planners-led village plans

Example: Durham County Council (1951)

>> 121 villages out of a total of 357 towns and villages in the county were at some time placed in Category D

- **technocratic planning**
- mining communities were continually and overwhelmingly understood by planners in **economic terms**
- **no serious consideration was ever given to the social and cultural formations** within the settlement structures
- policy makers seemingly held little regard for **community commitments and concerns**

(Pattison, 2004)

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Community-led regulatory village plans

Formal mechanisms

1) Village design statements (introduced in England in 1993)

>> involvement of local residents in the physical analysis of their villages to include the crafting of planning guidance around settlement structure, building form, design details, landscaping, street furniture and road layout

>> place distinctiveness

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Community-led regulatory village plans

Formal mechanisms

2) Neighbourhood plans (emerged out of Localism Act 2011 for England)

>> gives communities direct power to develop a shared vision for their neighbourhood and shape the development and growth of their local area; they are able to choose where they want new homes, shops and offices to be built, have their say on what those new buildings should look like and what infrastructure should be provided, and grant planning permission for the new buildings they want to see go ahead.

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Neigbourhood plans – possible negative consequnces:
>> an attempt to liberalise access to land for the volume house-builders in the context of a mismatch between housing need and housing supply

Rules:

- initiation by a **parish council or community organisation**
- approval for a defined neighbourhood boundary by the **local planning authority**
- a schedule of **consultation** and research to inform the preparation of a draft neighbourhood plan
- an **independent examination of draft policies** and site proposals (which have often been co-produced with guidance from local authority planners)
- a **neighbourhood planning referendum** which brings the neighbourhood plan into force when more than half of those voting from within the designated area boundary vote in favour of the neighbourhood plan

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Participatory planning

- group-based and taking up tasks passed over by government and private enterprise
  >> dependency of public funding
- must connect upwards and outwards
  >> formation of strategic alliances and partnership
- specific management style of groups is important
  >> they may lack the hands-on control and business sensitivity
- community groups may not fully reflect the diversity of local interests
  >> composition, mandate and purpose

Rural residents: seizing opportunities to express mutual, locality-oriented interest in collective actions

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Strategic planning

- strategic plan for a village looks forward over a period of years
- multi-dimensional and bring together different stakeholders
- a useful tool to prioritise the things that must be done by the constituent civil society groups in the village, more likely in partnership with others

3 The complementarity of participatory and strategic planning

Participatory and strategic village planning:

- can enhance the delivery of pilot and mainstream funding programmes
- can stimulate the private, voluntary and public sectors to higher levels of performance
- harness citizen enthusiasm for getting involved in making a contribution to these collective efforts

Result:
Village development strategies / village action plans - INFORMAL TOOLS

>> **public involvement in strategic village planning**:
a collective process of discovery to produce a transformative trajectory that is much more appropriate for local community and institutional realities

Key takeaways

- Material concerns of village planning:
  rural infrastructures and KSP

- Immaterial concerns of village planning:
  social infrastructure, local networks, combination of participatory and strategic planning tools

- Such fusion enables looking beyond the rural development as a land-use management paradigm cloaked with the language of environmental sustainability instead pointing to the arena of debate among those interest in village planning

DISCUSSION:

Based on what was previously elaborated during the lecture, reflect (individually or in small groups) on the following questions and provide clear argumentation for each answer. The answers may also be placed in Brightspace's Discussion section.

1. **What are the key material concerns of village planning?**
2. **What are the key immaterial concerns of village planning?**
3. **What is the most appropriate approach for village planning?**